of the Assam Rifles to fall back to a pre-determined defensive line as envisaged by Thorat, and quite another for the army to abandon its prepared defences and fall back to a line that exists only on a map. Palit's belated belief that Se-la as a natural barrier would prove to be a natural defensive position, even better suited than Bomdila, might have had merit if Se-la had been prepared for a fight. To move back after the Chinese had attacked was nothing short of suicide. In addition, the following points needed to be considered:

First, had Bum-la been reinforced, the Chinese were not likely to get past determined and resolute Indian troops. 13 Dogra, commanded by Lieutenant Colonel M. S. Oberoi, and 4 Garhwal Rifles were already in Tawang. Had Palit not stopped the forward movement of troops, at least three more battalions or at least some of their leading elements would have been in Tawang by the evening of 23 October, with enough troops to guard and protect the crucial Bridge 4 over the Tawang Chu.

Second, the rapid collapse of 7 Brigade at Nam Ka Chu and the subsequent retreat of 4 Division HQ from Zimithang would have created a major logistical problem for the Chinese who were chasing Niranjan Prasad. The column that could approach Tawang directly from Zimithang would have run into the Garhwalis who were guarding that axis, while 13 Dogra was protecting the route from Lumla to Tawang. Even if the Chinese had made a rush for Bridge 4 (as they did) on the morning of 24 October, Indian troops on either side of the Tawang Chu could have taken them on. One thing is almost certain: the Chinese could not have brought in a large number of troops but would have relied on tactics based on speed.

Third, Tawang was perhaps the best stocked position in the region. It was only after 8 September that the supply drops had been diverted to Tsangdhar; until then, the Indian Air Force had flown tons of equipment, ammunition and other logistical supplies into Tawang. Niranjan Prasad and Palit's decision nullified the entire logistical effort that had been put into place over months. Tawang was being handed over to the Chinese on a platter.

The message to withdraw from Bum-la and Tawang reached the 1 Sikh Battalion HQ at Milaktong-la much to the disbelief of Mehta and the other officers. However, there was no ambiguity in the orders issued by Brigadier Kalyan Singh, Commander 4 Artillery Brigade. The army commander's stance continued to be puzzling, for though he outwardly agreed with the